

KF18 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

This month we are focusing on KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

Any effort we make to train in meditation and mindfulness is worthwhile. We learn to endure the discomforts and struggle of learning a new skill. Through practice, we develop the courage to maintain a consistent direction, and we strengthen our ability to focus. Meditation supports our overall health by training our minds to abide in the present moment with the balanced and creative perspective of non-judgment. We learn to stop wasting our energy on illusions and limitless possibilities; instead, we invest our gifts in the immediate and the real.

At this point in your training, you may wish to print off the four exercises that you have been learning and practice each one for five minutes. You might adopt this as a daily plan, giving you twenty minutes of mindfulness and meditation practice. If you have little ones to care for, take short breaks throughout the day to meditate.

- For five minutes, make a list of what bothers you today and tell God about it. Then, practice the **3-Minute Breathing Space**.¹
- For five minutes, practice the **Maranatha Meditation**.²
- For five minutes, practice the **SALT Process**. You might choose to work on an item from the list of what is bothering you today.
- For five minutes, practice the **Mercy Meditation** focusing on either yourself or others.³

Just explore. Your purpose is to find a meditation practice that works for you. In this lesson, we will use the **Mercy Meditation** to extend mercy to another person. Let's begin.

Settle into your environment and observe your breathing. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Notice how your body softens on the exhale. *(Pause)* Scan your body for tension and give any tense areas permission to relax. Notice especially your face. Is there tension there? Relax. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Draw your mind away from the events of the day, from the past or the future, and from others, and focus on what is happening inside your own skin right now. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Allow a person to come to mind to whom you wish to extend mercy, or you might wish to consider a situation in which you find it difficult to extend mercy to someone. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

And now, as you think about that person, reflect for thirty seconds on each of the following three questions. You might jot down the thoughts you wish to remember.

1. In what areas am I most critical of this person? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause. If you haven't done so already, take thirty seconds to jot down what came to mind. You might write in your KF journal or on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. For what do I need to forgive this person? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause. Take a moment to jot down what came to mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. How do I treat this person when they make a mistake or do not live up to my standards? (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause, and write for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, use your imagination in a healthy way to experiment with bringing compassion to this person. You might call to mind someone who loves this person as they are. This might be someone divine, like God or Jesus, or perhaps someone mortal and human. You might call to mind one of God's other creatures. *(Pause)* As you breathe for one minute, observe whatever comes to mind and practice letting go of judgment. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause, take a deep breath, and re-engage with the meeting.

You will learn more about mercy in later lessons, but right now you are learning to let go of fear and judgment. This is a way of planting seeds of mercy, not only for others but also for yourself.

Our hymn of mercy is *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross*.

Were the whole realm of nature mine,
That were an offering far too small;
Love so amazing, so divine,
Demands my soul, my life, my all.⁴

Actually, there is no demand in karis; there is simply an invitation to generously respond to God's gift of salvation so that we may experience more and more of His amazing love.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

In this lesson we will explore the **Claim and Blame Worksheet**. This worksheet is designed to help you

identify and untangle your claims about what you think you deserve from others and from life. You might ask your Karis Link to explore it with you, and you might also sign up for other KF training opportunities.

Let's look briefly at the **Claim and Blame Worksheet** now.

Part One: You Are Here

1. Indicators and reactions

What feelings or reactions have let you know that you are misoriented? Your KF training begins with mindfulness because without this skill you cannot be aware of how you are feeling or notice how you are reacting, nor can you spot the events that trigger your feelings and reactions.

2. Identify your emotions

The **Claim and Blame Worksheet** deals with feelings that arise when an event seems unfair, when you can't get away with something, and when you are envious of what others do or have. Nancy has included a list of feelings that may be associated with your claim. However, you might recognize other feelings that are not on the list. Feel free to jot those down, too.

3. When and what?

Try to determine the event that invited you to take the Judgment Path. You can ask yourself: *When did I start feeling this way? Was there an event that I judged as bad or not good enough? What was that event?*

4. Restoring pride

Your sense of fairness or justice is often related to hurt pride. What do you imagine would fix your feelings and soothe your hurt pride?

Part Two: Looking Deeply

1. It's not fair!

Now you can use your imagination to go to an extreme of what you think would be fair. Why is this situation unfair and how does it threaten the *Glory of Me!*?

2. I deserve

You learned from Dr. Horney's book that you are averse to recognizing your own claims because you need these illusions to maintain your pride system. You may, therefore, find it difficult to identify your claims unless you feel frustrated, cheated, hurt, or compelled to retaliate. Keep in mind that judging as unfair what happens to others may also reveal a claim that you have for yourself. Write down what you believe you deserve in the situation—that is, in your situation, to what do you feel entitled?

3. My right to react

Now that you have defined what you think you deserve in the situation, you can identify the behaviors and choices that you use to redress the violation of your claim. When your claims are not met, what reactions do you feel you have a right to indulge? These reactions often seem rational, just, or understandable to us in the moment, but they are actually powered by judgment, hurt pride, and fear.

4. My perfect life

This question helps you define your claim. You get to laugh at yourself a little and explore the imagined

superiority of your wisdom and judgments. You also have the chance to be extravagantly and ludicrously honest with yourself.

Part 3: Recovery

1. Assess the judgment

Recall the **Two Paths Flowchart**. If you have judged an event as evil, you have probably felt fear. This is where you explore the fear and the evils that you imagined when your claim was not met. If your claim was met, you may have felt euphoria and judged the event as good. Perhaps by now you can see how your judgments are very partial, unrealistic, and unjust when they are based on a claim.

2. Identify the fear of loss

You have reacted because something has made mincemeat of your search for the *Glory of Me!*, and, as a result, you are gripped by fear, grief, and rage.

3. Stick to the facts

You can now take the Believe it Path and simply list the sequence of events. This is where you get real. You give up your judgments, detach from your feelings, and just look at the facts. As your True Self grows, you will become more interested in the truth than in your neurotic entitlements and compelling illusions which help you feel superior and protect your pride.

4. Make a decision

Perhaps at this point you are ready to let go of your judgments and are willing to deal with how things actually are.

5. Rejoice in the truth

As long as you continue to play with the pretend toys of your illusions, you will not learn the mature skills that you need for handling reality and building healthy relationships. Only the truth can set you free to live in humility and access the gifts of God's grace.

6. Take action: talk to God

God gives grace only to the humble; He extends an invitation of fellowship to the one who confesses the truth and is ready to make the effort to grow out of egocentric cravings. Pride is so destructive. It is the toxin that stunts your growth and hinders the lives of those around you. God must oppose your pride. He cannot support illusions and fantasies. He is true, and He is working to bring you into truth.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, loosen the grip of pride on my soul. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 4 reminds us of how we waste our energy in the service of the Idol. Let's hear it again:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

Jesus often encourages us to think through what we want, and in the Gospel of Matthew, chapter 5, He teaches us to be motivated by our wants rather than driven by the law of our shoulds.⁵ We can stop wasting our energy thinking, “I should do that,” and, instead, use our energy to ask, “What outcome do I want, and how do I get it?”

The text for our lesson is **Matthew 5:3–10**. We will be reading this well-known passage in Nancy’s translation.

³Happy are beggars in spirit who are continually pleading and crying out for spiritual connection, because the kingdom of heaven is theirs.

⁴Happy are those who truly mourn, because they are the ones who shall be comforted by someone who is called alongside to help.

⁵Happy are the mild and gentle, for they shall inherit the earth.

⁶Happy are those who hunger and thirst for orientation, because they are the ones that shall be satisfied like grazing herds in a spring meadow.

⁷Happy are the compassionate and merciful, for they are the ones who shall receive help, compassion, and mercy.

⁸Happy are the single-minded, pruned, purified by fire, and free from their guilty, craving hearts, because they are the ones who shall see God.

⁹Happy are those who generate peace, for they shall be called the sons of God and carry the authority of His name.

¹⁰Happy are those who have been persecuted for the sake of orientation, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.

Take a deep breath.

Jesus tells us how to be happy, blessed, and favored. He also exposes the lies we tell ourselves about what would make us happy. He invites us to build a happy life by developing oriented qualities and choosing oriented behaviors. Unfortunately, oriented behaviors are difficult to learn when we are caught in the grip of the Idol’s pride system. It is much easier to claim to possess Christian qualities than it is to grow them in our lives.

Jesus says that if we want to know real, abiding happiness and experience the karis favor of God, we must recognize the poverty of our Idol’s pride system and choose another kind of poverty—we must become beggars in the spirit. Beggars learn quickly what works and what doesn’t work. They are highly motivated to get their needs met and don’t waste their energy gratifying their pride. No beggar comes to a time when he can stop begging. The hunger and thirst that he feels today he will feel tomorrow. The beggar keeps begging until he dies. In KF, we learn to keep begging every day for the needs of our soul to be met and for an ever-expanding spiritual connection with God—and as long as we are training here in this material world, we will need to keep begging.

Look at the list of beatitudes in Matthew 5. Each line begins with the word *happy*. Do you want to be happy, or favored? Perhaps you have a claim that you deserve happiness because you have certain beliefs. You might envy the apparent happiness of others and yet ignore the ways in which you are making yourself unhappy. Do you know that it is within your power to be happy, favored, and blessed? Look at the causes of happiness at the end of the sentences in our text. We are happy because we have spiritual

authority, because we are comforted, because we are satisfied, because we can see God. In order to produce the effect of being happy, Jesus says that you must develop certain qualities and make certain choices. These qualities and choices are the cause that produces the effect of your happiness. For example, if you want spiritual authority, you must choose to be a beggar in the spirit; if you want to see God working in your life, you must become single-minded. The unwillingness to develop these qualities and make these choices is what interferes with your happiness and well-being.

What do you really want?

Trying to motivate yourself by what you think you should do will not help you productively endure in every situation or in the long run. If you want to achieve your desired outcomes, you will need to learn to motivate yourself by what you really want. Rather than thinking, “I should hunger and thirst for spiritual connection,” you might realize that what you really want is to be satisfied. On the other hand, you might claim that you do hunger and thirst for spiritual connection, or orientation, but your lack of satisfaction is evidence that your claim has no substance. How do you become satisfied? Jesus tells you how. Refuse to prop up your pride system. Learn to keep asking, seeking, and knocking for orientation—just as a hungry person asks, seeks, and knocks for food—and you will become satisfied.

We might compare the motivation of shoulds with the motivation of real wanting. Listen to the following statements and use your mindfulness training to observe your emotional reactions:

- I should be a beggar in the spirit.
- I should hunger and thirst for orientation.
- I should be mild and gentle.
- I should be a peacemaker.

How does that feel? *(Pause for 5 seconds)*

Now, observe your emotions when you hear the following statements:

- I want spiritual authority.
- I want to be satisfied and fulfilled.
- I want to inherit the earth.
- I want peace within and around me.

(Pause for 5 seconds)

Does this second list of statements feel less tense, more single-minded, and more congruent—more like the voice of your True Self? Does your body feel less strain? *(Pause for 5 seconds)*

So, what is preventing you from accessing God’s provision of happiness or well-being? This might seem a little crazy, but there are days and even years when we do not want to have spiritual authority, receive mercy, be at peace, or be satisfied. The problem is that a big part of us does not want to be well. Our pride stands in the way. But the good news is that we can allow ourselves to be messed up in our feelings and still choose life. No matter what you feel, choose life.⁶ As you taste real life and its outcomes, you will discover how worthwhile it is to keep choosing life.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, I am willing to be happy. Show me how to get there. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider the power to choose the outcomes of your own life. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider the power to choose the outcomes of your own life*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness as you *consider the power to choose the outcomes of your own life*. You might notice a compulsion to argue with yourself or with God, to judge yourself and others, or to make up stories. Give yourself permission now to explore your experience, without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing as you *consider the power to choose the outcomes of your own life*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* For example, you might recognize what doubt, panic, or hope feels like in your body. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider your power to choose the outcomes of your own life*. What do you believe about your power? *(Pause)* How might your Idol's pride be hurt if you accepted this power to choose? *(Pause)* It's OK if you don't know. Just observe how you respond, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

You might imagine a door of opportunity opening before you. As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

(Pause for 8 seconds or long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your power to choose.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth as He teaches you about your design and authority.
- Welcome the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁷

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I develop my power to choose, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, responsibility and self-determination.
- As I develop my power to choose, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, appreciation and affection.
- As I develop my power to choose, I let go of the longing for, or the fear of, security and comfort.
- As I develop my power to choose, I let go of the fear of changing my outcomes and becoming happy. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are grateful for this time together to heal and to train. Hold us in the power of this redirected energy as You guide us to our real glory. Show us the next step in our healing this week. We want to co-labor with You so that we can access all of Your karis gifts in this life and the next, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ Zindel Segal, J. Mark G Williams and John D Teasdale, *Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy for Depression* (New York: The Guilford Press, 2013), 208. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² Laurence Freeman, Editor, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main* (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

³ www.livingmindfully.org/. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

⁴ *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross* by Isaac Watts (1674–1748), youtu.be/U-hz6L6LAug.

⁵ Mark 10:51.

⁶ Deut. 30:19.

⁷ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.